

9.11 Miscellaneous Tips

Here are some additional things you can do to keep your computer running smoothly.

- Clean out your browser cache from time to time. This is a good thing to do if you notice your browser running slowly, as the allotted space for the cache may be full, and it takes time to clear out old images that haven't been accessed in a long time to make room for the new images to be cached.

Also, if you need to load a page with lots of images, such as a page of family picture, but you realise your browser stalls out before all the pictures have loaded, it's time to do some cleaning. In Internet Explorer, point to Tools > Internet Options, and under Temporary Internet Files, click 'Delete Files'. You can also use the 'Settings' button to, amongst other things, tweak how much of disk space to use for the cache.

- Run a thorough virus scan at least once a month. You'll naturally be doing this if your computer seems a bit wonky, but it's a good idea to do it on a regular basis.

Most anti-virus programs have three scan modes—quick, standard, and thorough. You should choose the 'thorough' mode for scanning at least once a month or once in two months.

- If a program has installed a toolbar on your browser, don't take it lying down! It may not be this easy, but one thing you can do is go to 'Add or Remove Programs' (in the Control Panel) and find a strange program, which will probably have the word "Toolbar" in the name. Remove it and restart your browser.
- Every now and then—say once in six months or so—use Device Manager to check for driver upgrades to your hardware. Simply double-click the device, go to the Driver tab, and select 'Update Driver', as explained in section 9.3. Also, for firmware upgrades, you'll need to go to the manufacturer's Web site and provide the model number of your device.